AI PRODUCT MANAGEMENT 2 · DETAILED COURSE

Product Management Foundations

What a product manager does, how the role differs from its neighbours, and how a product moves from idea to growth. This subject sets the vocabulary used in every later subject.

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CHAPTER 01

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Introduction to Product Management

The discipline of deciding what to build, for whom and why, then guiding it from idea to a product that delivers customer and business value.

Product management connects customer problems, business goals and technical feasibility. A PM decides what to build and why, then makes sure it reaches customers. Example: a fintech app notices users abandon KYC; the PM frames the problem before any feature is discussed.

Evolution of Product Management

From brand and packaged-goods managers, through software and agile teams, to today's data-driven and AI-assisted product teams.

The role grew from brand management at consumer goods firms to software product management in the 2000s, and now includes data-driven and AI-assisted practice. Knowing this history explains why modern PMs are expected to run experiments and understand technology.

Product Manager Roles and Responsibilities

Owning the problem, vision, strategy, roadmap, priorities and outcomes, and aligning engineering, design, data, marketing and sales around them.

A PM owns the problem, the vision, the roadmap and the outcome metrics, but not the team. Influence comes from clarity: writing decisions down, sharing evidence and keeping engineering, design and sales aligned on one goal.

Product Manager vs Product Owner vs Project Manager vs Business Analyst

PM owns the why and what; the product owner manages the backlog in Scrum; the project manager owns schedule and delivery; the analyst owns detailed requirements and process.

The PM owns the product strategy and outcomes. The product owner manages the backlog inside a Scrum team. The project manager tracks schedule, budget and delivery. The business analyst details requirements and processes. Confusion between these roles causes most early friction in new teams.

Product Manager vs Product Analyst vs Product Operations

The analyst answers questions with data; product operations builds the processes, tooling and insights that let PMs work faster; the PM decides what to do.

The analyst answers questions with data and builds dashboards. Product operations builds the processes, tools and data pipelines that let teams work well. The PM turns those inputs into decisions about what to build next.

Types of Product Managers

Core, technical, growth, platform, data, AI, B2B, B2C and enterprise PMs, each weighting skills differently.

Core PMs ship features in one area, technical PMs own platforms and APIs, growth PMs optimise funnels, and AI PMs manage uncertainty from models. Pick the type that matches your background, then build the skills it needs.

Product Lifecycle Management

Managing a product through introduction, growth, maturity and decline, adjusting strategy, investment and metrics at each stage.

Products move through introduction, growth, maturity and decline. Each stage needs different investment: acquisition early, retention and cost control in maturity, and a sunset plan at the end. Example: a legacy reporting tool may be kept alive only for a few enterprise clients.

Product Discovery vs Product Delivery

Discovery decides what is worth building through research and experiments; delivery builds and ships it. Strong teams run both continuously.

Discovery answers whether a problem is worth solving, using interviews, prototypes and experiments. Delivery builds and ships the validated solution reliably. Teams that skip discovery build well-engineered features nobody uses.

Product Thinking and Customer-Centricity

Starting from the customer's problem and the outcome they want, then working back to features, instead of starting from solutions.

Product thinking starts from the user's job and pain, not from a solution a stakeholder wants. Ask what changes for the customer if you ship the feature. A useful test is whether you can state the problem without mentioning your product.

Product Vision, Mission and Objectives

Mission says why the company exists, vision describes the future state the product enables, and objectives set the measurable steps toward it.

The mission explains why the company exists. The vision describes the future the product enables, for example a world where every small shop can accept digital payments. Objectives break that vision into measurable steps for the next quarter or year.

Product Strategy Fundamentals

A coherent set of choices on where to play and how to win, backed by evidence about customers, market and capabilities.

Strategy is a set of choices about which customers to serve, which problems to solve and how to win against alternatives. A good strategy states what you will not do. Without that, roadmaps become lists of requests.

Product-Market Fit

The point at which a product satisfies strong market demand, seen in retention, organic growth and customers who would be very disappointed to lose it.

Product-market fit means a clear group of customers depends on the product and would be disappointed if it disappeared. Signs include retention that flattens over time, organic referrals and growing willingness to pay. It is a milestone you test for, not a feeling.

Product-Led Growth

A model where the product itself drives acquisition, conversion and expansion, through free tiers, trials, self-serve onboarding and viral loops.

In product-led growth the product itself drives acquisition and expansion through free tiers, self-serve onboarding and sharing features. Slack and Dropbox are common examples. It works best when value is visible within minutes of signing up.

B2B, B2C, B2B2C and SaaS Product Models

Who buys and who uses differ by model: businesses, consumers, businesses serving consumers, and subscription software delivered online.

B2B sells to organisations with long sales cycles and many stakeholders. B2C sells to consumers at scale with simpler decisions. B2B2C sells through a business to consumers, such as a bank offering a loan app through an employer. SaaS is subscription software delivered online, which shapes pricing and retention work.

Product Management Operating Models

How product work is organised: feature teams, stream-aligned teams, platform teams, centralised or embedded PMs, and how they plan together.

Teams organise around features, streams of value or platforms. Some companies embed PMs in each team, others centralise them. The right model depends on how much coordination the product needs and how fast the company changes direction.

Product Management Career Paths

Associate PM to PM, senior, group, director and CPO, plus branches into specialist, founder and AI product roles.

A common path runs associate PM, PM, senior PM, group PM, director and chief product officer. Specialist paths in AI, growth or platforms are also valid. Build depth in one area and breadth in the others.

Summary of terms

Term	Meaning
Introduction to Product Management	The discipline of deciding what to build, for whom and why, then guiding it from idea to a product that delivers customer and business value.
Evolution of Product Management	From brand and packaged-goods managers, through software and agile teams, to today's data-driven and AI-assisted product teams.

Product Manager Roles and Responsibilities	Owning the problem, vision, strategy, roadmap, priorities and outcomes, and aligning engineering, design, data, marketing and sales around them.
Product Manager vs Product Owner vs Project Manager vs Business Analyst	PM owns the why and what; the product owner manages the backlog in Scrum; the project manager owns schedule and delivery; the analyst owns detailed requirements and process.
Product Manager vs Product Analyst vs Product Operations	The analyst answers questions with data; product operations builds the processes, tooling and insights that let PMs work faster; the PM decides what to do.
Types of Product Managers	Core, technical, growth, platform, data, AI, B2B, B2C and enterprise PMs, each weighting skills differently.
Product Lifecycle Management	Managing a product through introduction, growth, maturity and decline, adjusting strategy, investment and metrics at each stage.
Product Discovery vs Product Delivery	Discovery decides what is worth building through research and experiments; delivery builds and ships it. Strong teams run both continuously.
Product Thinking and Customer-Centricity	Starting from the customer's problem and the outcome they want, then working back to features, instead of starting from solutions.
Product Vision, Mission and Objectives	Mission says why the company exists, vision describes the future state the product enables, and objectives set the measurable steps toward it.
Product Strategy Fundamentals	A coherent set of choices on where to play and how to win, backed by evidence about customers, market and capabilities.
Product-Market Fit	The point at which a product satisfies strong market demand, seen in retention, organic growth and customers who would be very disappointed to lose it.
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B2B, B2C, B2B2C and SaaS Product Models	Who buys and who uses differ by model: businesses, consumers, businesses serving consumers, and subscription software delivered online.
Product Management Operating Models	How product work is organised: feature teams, stream-aligned teams, platform teams, centralised or embedded PMs, and how they plan together.
Product Management Career Paths	Associate PM to PM, senior, group, director and CPO, plus branches into specialist, founder and AI product roles.

Practice exercise: Write a one-page job description for the PM of a product you use, then list three decisions that PM owns and three they only influence.

Self-check

1. Explain Introduction to Product Management in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.
2. Explain Product Thinking and Customer-Centricity in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.
3. Explain Product Management Career Paths in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.

Related SkillNavora material

- AI Product Management (original programme): The programme you already have: PM Master Handbook, PRD and BRD templates, interview prep.
- Interactive PM Handbook: 23 modules: product core, AI tools lab, frameworks, case studies and interview prep.
- Product Operations: Free PDF, basic to advanced.
- AI Tutor: Ask questions on any topic.
- Study Library: Every lesson, class and PDF by programme.

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